Operatives live dangerously and on the edge. Their heroic exploits are locked away. There are no medals pinned on the chests of intelligence operatives. For spooks, emotions are killed before inception. For instance, the first successful strike against Pakistan during the 1999 Kargil war was mounted by eighty battle-trained covert action operatives of the R&AW. The team captured key locations and largely returned victorious. But some fell to the enemy's guns. Their names did not figure in the lists of martyrs. When TV channels began telecasting public ceremonies to honour the defence forces' fallen heroes, the agency's top brass were emotionally overwhelmed. Operatives who had lost friends and colleagues in the Kargil war watched the spectacle helplessly. An officer code-named Rehman requested the top boss to acknowledge the sacrifice of the operatives who never returned. A message was sent to Brajesh Mishra, then national security advisor and principal secretary to Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Mishra opposed the proposal. Nevertheless, the message was conveyed to Vajpayee. In a closed conference room at 7 Race Course Road, the prime minister's official residence, the names of eighteen R&AW officers were read aloud, along with details of their gallant performances on the Kargil battlefields. For the first time in the history of the R&AW, special medals were presented to these warriors in the shadows. Vajpayee shook hands with top R&AW officers and expressed his deep gratitude for the supreme sacrifice made by these unsung heroes. No records of this meeting were kept. No government press release was issued for the next day's newspapers. No photographs were published on the prime minister's website. After the ceremony, the officers quietly retreated to their invisible world to work, taking their secrets to bed.

BLOODBATH IN BANGLADESH